DIGITALAIKART WORKING KIT

GSTR-9 Filing Kit FY 2025-26

The annual return, the 30 November ITC cliff and the 31 December deadline

FY 2025-26 · due 31 December 2026

For proprietors, partners, directors and the accountants who file for them

Position checked 13 November 2026

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Read this page first

Two dates decide how much this year's annual return costs you. One is 30 November 2026, when the window to claim last year's missed input tax credit shuts. The other is 31 December 2026, when GSTR-9 is due. If you file the return before 30 November, you close the first window early — on the day you file. That single sequencing mistake is the most expensive one in this cycle.

This kit is a working document, not an explainer. It assumes you have your GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, GSTR-2B and books for April 2025 to March 2026 in front of you, and it walks you from that pile to a filed return. Every table of the form is covered, in the order the portal presents it, with what auto-populates, what you type, and where people get it wrong.

What is inside

- **Part 1** — the calendar: what closes on 30 November, what closes on 31 December, and the early-filing trap.
- **Part 2** — whether you file at all: the ₹2 crore test done on aggregate turnover, not on your State ledger.
- **Part 3** — the four-column master working paper that feeds every table.
- **Parts 4 to 6** — a table-by-table walkthrough of GSTR-9, including the FY 2025-26 relaxations.
- **Part 7** — the GST 2.0 split year: how the 22 September 2025 rate change lands in your annual return.
- **Parts 8 to 9** — IMS, Table 8A, and the ITC clean-up that has to finish before 30 November.
- **Parts 10 to 13** — mismatch intimations, GSTR-9C, late fee arithmetic, and the cost of not filing.
- **Parts 14 to 16** — filing-day runbook, the mistakes that cost money, and a 48-day plan with a checklist.

How to use it

1. Read Part 1 today. It changes the order in which you do everything else.
2. Run the Part 2 test on your PAN-level turnover. If you are exempt, stop — you are done in five minutes.
3. Build the working paper in Part 3 before you open the portal. The portal is the last step, not the first.
4. Use Parts 4 to 6 with the form open on a second screen.
5. Keep Part 16's checklist on paper and tick it as you go.

SCOPE AND HONEST LIMITS

This is general information about the GST annual return as it stands on 13 November 2026, written for Indian registered businesses and the people who prepare their returns. It is not tax advice on your particular facts, and it cannot be: the answer to most GSTR-9 questions depends on documents only you hold. Where a position is unsettled or a portal parameter is unpublished, this kit says so instead of inventing a number. Confirm anything that carries real money with a practising chartered accountant, and confirm dates on gst.gov.in before you rely on them.

PART 1

The calendar

30 November and 31 December 2026, and why the order matters

Five provisions of the CGST Act use the same cut-off: the thirtieth day of November following the end of the financial year, **or the date of furnishing the annual return, whichever is earlier**. The Finance Act, 2022 moved these windows from the September return to 30 November, effective 1 October 2022. A sixth date, under Rule 37A, is a reversal deadline that also falls on 30 November.

Date	What it is	Consequence of missing it
20 Nov 2026	GSTR-3B for October 2026 (monthly filers)	Late fee and interest; and if it is your last chance to claim FY 2025-26 credit, the credit can be lost.
22 or 24 Oct 2026	GSTR-3B for July–September 2026 (QRMP filers, State-wise date)	Already past. For a QRMP filer this was the last regular return before the 30 November window closed.
30 Nov 2026	Last date for FY 2025-26 input tax credit under section 16(4); credit notes under section 34(2); GSTR-1 amendments under section 37(3); GSTR-3B corrections under section 39(9); Rule 37A reversals	The credit or correction is lost for good; unreversed Rule 37A credit becomes payable with interest.
31 Dec 2026	GSTR-9 annual return, and GSTR-9C where turnover exceeds ₹5 crore	Late fee from 1 January 2027, per GSTIN, until the complete annual return is filed.
30 Jun 2030	Last date for a show-cause notice under section 74A for FY 2025-26 (42 months from the due date of the annual return)	Not a deadline you file against — but it is why a sloppy return stays open for years.

The early-filing trap, in one worked example

Section 16(4) bars credit on an invoice after 30 November following the end of the financial year, or after the annual return is filed, whichever is earlier. Filing GSTR-9 on 15 November therefore closes the ITC window on 15 November, not 30 November.

Day	What happens	Result
12 Nov 2026	You find a February 2026 purchase invoice with ₹1,80,000 of tax never claimed in GSTR-3B	Still claimable — in the October 2026 GSTR-3B due 20 November.
15 Nov 2026	You file GSTR-9 for FY 2025-26 to get it off your desk	The section 16(4) window now closes today. The October return filed on 20 November is too late.
20 Nov 2026	You file the October GSTR-3B and try to claim the ₹1,80,000	Barred. The credit is gone; the tax is a cost.

The numbers in that table are illustrative. The mechanism is not. If there is any chance you have unclaimed FY 2025-26 credit sitting in GSTR-2B, the correct order is: claim it in the last GSTR-3B that falls on or before 30 November, then file GSTR-9. Never the other way round.

> **THE ONE-LINE RULE**
> Claim first, return later. File the annual return only after every FY 2025-26 credit, credit note and amendment you intend to make has already gone into a GSTR-3B or GSTR-1 that was accepted by the portal.

What the portal will not let you do

GSTR-9 and GSTR-9C for FY 2025-26 were enabled on the GST portal from 8 October 2026. The forms open only when every GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for FY 2025-26 has been filed — a single pending return for April 2025 keeps the annual return locked. Tables 4, 5, 6, 8 and 9 then arrive pre-filled from your own GSTR-1, GSTR-2B and GSTR-3B, which is precisely why the working paper in Part 3 exists: you are checking the portal's arithmetic against your books, not typing from scratch.

Two portal features are worth knowing before you start. Table 8A has a companion download on the GSTR-9 dashboard called “Download Table 8A document details”, an invoice-level Excel of what the portal counted. The online 8A and the Excel can differ — the Excel carries some records the online figure excludes, such as outward supplies under reverse charge and certain cross-year amendments. Where they differ, the online 8A is the figure the return uses; the Excel is for tracing individual invoices.

PART 2

Do you file at all?

The ₹2 crore test, done properly

Notification No. 15/2025-Central Tax dated 17 September 2025 exempts registered persons whose aggregate turnover in the financial year is up to ₹2 crore from filing the annual return, for FY 2024-25 and onwards. The words “and onwards” matter: the exemption no longer has to be re-issued each autumn, so for FY 2025-26 you are not waiting on a fresh notification. Below ₹2 crore, GSTR-9 is optional — you may still file voluntarily.

Aggregate turnover, FY 2025-26 (PAN level)	GSTR-9	GSTR-9C
Up to ₹2 crore	Optional (exempt, may file voluntarily)	Not required
Above ₹2 crore, up to ₹5 crore	Mandatory	Not required
Above ₹5 crore	Mandatory	Mandatory, self-certified
Exactly ₹5 crore	Mandatory	Not required — Rule 80(3) says “exceeds” five crore

Aggregate turnover is not the number on your State return

Aggregate turnover under section 2(6) is the value of all taxable supplies, exempt supplies, exports and inter-State supplies of every person with the same PAN, computed on an all-India basis. It excludes the GST and cess you charged, and excludes inward supplies on which you pay tax under reverse charge. It is not your taxable turnover, and it is not one State's figure.

A business with ₹1.4 crore in Maharashtra and ₹0.9 crore in Gujarat has aggregate turnover of ₹2.3 crore. Both registrations must file GSTR-9, even though neither State's own figure crosses ₹2 crore. Reading the threshold off a single State's books is how a business discovers a missed annual return a year later, when the late fee has already run into five figures on each GSTIN.

Who files, and who does not

Taxpayer	FY 2025-26 position
Normal taxpayer, aggregate turnover above ₹2 crore	GSTR-9 mandatory, GSTIN by GSTIN
Normal taxpayer, aggregate turnover up to ₹2 crore	Exempt; may file voluntarily
SEZ unit or SEZ developer	Same rules as a normal taxpayer
Registration cancelled during the year	File for the period the registration was active
Composition taxpayer (section 10)	Outside GSTR-9; the annual requirement is met through GSTR-4

Taxpayer	FY 2025-26 position
Input Service Distributor	Not required
TDS deductor (section 51), TCS operator (section 52)	Not required
Casual taxable person, non-resident taxable person	Not required
OIDAR supplier from outside India	Not required

CHECK THE EXEMPTION BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

A standing exemption can be narrowed as easily as it was granted. Before you decide not to file, check gst.gov.in for any later notification, and record the date you checked. The cost of being wrong is a late fee that starts running on 1 January 2027 on every GSTIN you hold.

What voluntary filing buys a small business

Below ₹2 crore, filing GSTR-9 is optional but not pointless. It puts a year of declared turnover, tax and credit on record in one document, which is what a bank asks for in a working-capital review and what an assessing officer reads first. It also forces the reconciliation that catches credit you never claimed — and under section 16(4) that credit has an expiry date. If you have a lender, a tender or a prospective investor in your next twelve months, file it.

If you are exempt and decide not to file, put the decision in writing with the turnover working, and keep it with your records. Records must be preserved for 72 months from the due date of the annual return for the year (section 36), so for FY 2025-26 that runs to 31 December 2032.

PART 3

The master working paper

One sheet that feeds every table in the form

Every expensive GSTR-9 mistake comes from the same root: the return is prepared on the portal, from the portal's own auto-populated numbers, without an independent sheet that says what the right answer is. Build the sheet first. Four columns of annual figures, reconciled once, will answer almost every row the form asks for.

The four columns

Column	Source	What it proves
A. Books	Tally, Zoho Books, Busy, Marg or your Excel sales and purchase registers, April 2025 to March 2026	The truth as your accounts state it: turnover, tax charged, credit taken, credit reversed.
B. GSTR-1 (annual)	Sum of all GSTR-1, IFF and GSTR-1A filings for the twelve months, plus amendments filed in FY 2026-27 up to 30 November 2026	What you told the department you sold.
C. GSTR-3B (annual)	Sum of the twelve returns: outward tax, ITC availed, ITC reversed, RCM, tax paid in cash and credit	What you told the department you owed and paid.
D. GSTR-2B and IMS	Twelve monthly 2B statements plus the IMS action history for the year	What the department says was available to you as credit.

Column D is new in substance, not just in name. Section 38 was substituted by Notification No. 16/2025-Central Tax dated 17 September 2025, with the procedure codified by the CGST (Fourth Amendment) Rules, 2025 (Notification No. 18/2025-Central Tax dated 31 October 2025). From the October 2025 tax period, GSTR-2B is built from the action you take in the Invoice Management System: accepted records flow in, rejected records do not, pending records wait. An invoice you never touched is deemed accepted when 2B is generated on the 14th. Table 8A of GSTR-9 now draws on that same data.

The eight reconciliations to run, in this order

1. **Turnover: books vs GSTR-1.** Expect a difference for credit notes issued after year-end, and for invoices raised in March but reported in April's GSTR-1. Explain each line; do not net them into one adjustment.
2. **Turnover: GSTR-1 vs GSTR-3B.** Should be nil for most months since July 2025, when outward liability in 3B became auto-populated from GSTR-1, IFF and GSTR-1A and could no longer be edited. Any gap is from older periods or from RCM and amendments.
3. **Output tax: 3B vs books.** A difference here is a rate error or a classification error, and it is the difference Table 9 will expose.

4. **ITC: 2B (post-IMS) vs 3B.** This is Table 8D. A positive 8D means credit was available and not taken — and it is now racing the 30 November deadline.
5. **ITC: books vs 3B.** Credit in your purchase register that never reached a return is either ineligible or missed. Decide which, per invoice.
6. **Reversals: 3B Table 4(B)(2) vs Table 7 of GSTR-9.** Every reversal must land in a row of Table 7, or the return shows credit you do not have.
7. **RCM: 3B vs books vs Table 4L/4M.** RCM inward supplies appear twice — once as a liability, once as credit. Half-reported RCM is the most common cause of a 9C that will not balance.
8. **Cash and credit: 3B payments vs electronic cash and credit ledgers.** The annual totals must agree to the rupee, or Table 9 will not match the ledger and the return will look wrong even when the tax is right.

Build it as one sheet, not eight

In practice the sheet is 14 columns and one row per month, with a total row at the bottom. Across the top: month, taxable value per books, taxable value per GSTR-1, output IGST/CGST/SGST/cess per 3B, ITC available per 2B, ITC availed per 3B, ITC reversed, RCM liability, RCM credit, cash paid, credit utilised. Below the monthly block, a second block of exception rows: credit notes, debit notes, amendments, invoices claimed late, invoices rejected in IMS, Rule 37A candidates, and advance receipts.

That one sheet answers Tables 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10 to 14 and, for a ₹5 crore-plus business, most of GSTR-9C. It is also the document you hand an officer who asks how a figure was arrived at, three years from now.

KEEP THE SHEET, NOT JUST THE RETURN

Once the return is filed, the portal keeps the filed form and you keep the working. Store the sheet, the twelve GSTR-2B downloads, the IMS action export, the Table 8A Excel and the ARN together in one folder named for the financial year. Section 74A gives the department 42 months from the due date of this return to issue a notice — to 30 June 2030 for FY 2025-26 — and the sheet is what you will answer with.

PART 4

GSTR-9, table by table

Outward supplies, ITC and tax paid (Tables 4 to 9)

GSTR-9 is organised in six parts. Part I is basic details, Part II covers outward supplies (Tables 4 and 5), Part III covers input tax credit (Tables 6, 7 and 8), Part IV is tax paid (Table 9), Part V covers transactions of the previous financial year reported late (Tables 10 to 14), and Part VI covers demands, composition and job work, HSN summaries and late fee (Tables 15 to 19).

BEFORE YOU TYPE A SINGLE FIGURE

The row labels below follow the FY 2025-26 form. GSTN revises the form most years, so read the label on screen as you fill each row. Where this kit and the portal disagree, the portal is right and the label wins.

Table 4 — outward supplies and inward supplies under reverse charge

Table 4 is the annual summary of everything you supplied, adjusted for credit notes, debit notes and amendments, plus the inward supplies on which you paid tax under reverse charge. It is split into rows so that the tax treatment of each stream stays visible.

Row	What goes in it	Where it comes from
4A	Taxable outward supplies other than those in 4B to 4N — your ordinary domestic sales	GSTR-1 Table 4A/4B/4C net of credit notes; auto-populated
4B	Outward supplies on which the recipient pays tax (reverse charge outward)	GSTR-1 Table 4B; nil for most businesses
4C	Zero-rated supplies — exports without payment of tax	GSTR-1 Table 6A
4D	Zero-rated supplies to SEZ units or developers without payment of tax	GSTR-1 Table 6B
4E	Deemed exports	GSTR-1 Table 6C
4F	Advances received in FY 2025-26 on which tax was paid	GSTR-1 Table 11A, Part I
4G	Advances received earlier, tax paid earlier, invoice issued in FY 2025-26	GSTR-1 Table 11A, Part II
4H	Credit notes issued in FY 2025-26 against supplies of FY 2025-26	GSTR-1 Table 9B
4I	Credit notes issued in FY 2025-26 against supplies of an earlier year	GSTR-1 Table 9B, amendments
4J	Amendments increasing supplies declared in an earlier year	GSTR-1 Table 9A, upward
4K	Amendments reducing supplies declared in an earlier year	GSTR-1 Table 9A, downward

Row	What goes in it	Where it comes from
4L	Inward supplies on which you paid tax under reverse charge, declared in GSTR-3B	3B Table 3.1(d)
4M	Credit notes relating to those reverse-charge inward supplies	Purchase register
4N	Amendments to reverse-charge inward supplies of an earlier year	Purchase register

Where Table 4 goes wrong

- **Advances.** Rows 4F and 4G exist so that tax on an advance is counted once, in the year it was paid. Businesses that never tracked advances leave both rows at nil and overstate turnover in 4A by the value of invoices later raised against advances.
- **Credit notes issued in April 2026.** A credit note dated 12 April 2026 for a March 2026 sale is not in Table 4H — it belongs in the next-year bridge, Tables 10 to 14, filed by 30 November 2026. Getting this wrong double-counts the reduction.
- **Reverse charge.** 4L is where a landlord's rent, a lawyer's fee, a GTA freight bill or an import of service lands. It must equal the RCM liability you declared in 3B Table 3.1(d) for the year, month by month.
- **Export rows.** 4C and 4D are for supplies *without* payment of tax. Exports made on payment of IGST and refunded belong in Table 5, not here.

Table 5 — supplies where no GST is payable

Table 5 collects everything that left your premises without GST being charged: zero-rated supplies made on payment of tax and refunded, deemed exports, exempt supplies, nil-rated supplies and non-GST supplies, together with their credit notes, debit notes and amendments.

Stream	What it is	Common Indian example
Zero-rated on payment	Exports or SEZ supplies where IGST was charged and refund claimed	Goods exported on payment of IGST
Deemed exports	Supplies treated as exports under section 147	Supplies to an EOU against advance authorisation
Exempt	Supplies exempt by notification	Services by way of pure labour contracts for Government; certain agricultural produce
Nil-rated	Goods in the nil schedule	UHT milk, fresh produce, Indian breads after 22 September 2025
Non-GST	Goods outside GST entirely	Petroleum crude, high-speed diesel, alcohol for human consumption

The FY 2025-26 relaxations on this table

The instructions for FY 2025-26 carry options that make Table 5 far less painful than it used to be:

- Exempt and nil-rated supplies may be clubbed together and reported in the exempt row, instead of being split.
- Supplies in rows 5A to 5F may be reported net of the credit notes, debit notes and amendments that relate to them, rather than reporting gross supplies and the notes separately.

- Non-GST supplies must still be shown separately — that relaxation does not extend to them.

Use the clubbing option, but keep the split in your working paper. If a refund or an assessment later turns on the exempt-versus-nil-rated distinction, the sheet is where the answer lives.

Table 6 — input tax credit availed

Table 6 is the gross credit you availed during the year, by source. Table 6A is auto-populated from GSTR-3B and cannot be edited; the rows below it are where you break the figure into its parts. Row 6A1 is the one to watch: it was introduced for FY 2024-25 and carries credit relating to the preceding year claimed during this year, including credit reclaimed after a Rule 37 or Rule 37A reversal.

Row	What it carries
6A	Total ITC availed in GSTR-3B for the year — auto-populated, not editable
6A1	ITC of FY 2024-25 claimed in FY 2025-26, including Rule 37 and Rule 37A re-claims
6A2	Net ITC, derived from the rows below
6B	ITC on inward supplies other than reverse charge and imports — split into inputs, input services and capital goods
6C	ITC on inward supplies under reverse charge from unregistered persons
6D	ITC on inward supplies under reverse charge from registered persons
6E	ITC on import of goods
6F	ITC on import of services
6G	ITC distributed by an Input Service Distributor
6H	ITC reclaimed, where it was availed and reversed in an earlier year (Rule 37 and Rule 37A only)

Two relaxations apply for FY 2025-26 and one has been withdrawn. You may report ITC on inputs and ITC on input services together in the inputs column, for rows 6B, 6C and 6D. You may not do that for 6E: the relaxation that allowed import-of-goods credit to be clubbed was withdrawn from FY 2024-25. And the option to leave rows 12 and 13 blank, which existed in earlier years, has also been withdrawn — those rows must now be filled.

THE 6B SPLIT IS NOT COSMETIC

Reporting inputs, input services and capital goods in the right columns is what lets the department test your Rule 42 and Rule 43 reversals. A business that puts everything in the inputs column looks like it never reversed anything on capital goods, and that is exactly the profile that attracts a query.

Table 7 — reversals and ineligible credit

Table 7 is the mirror of Table 6: credit you availed and then gave back, or never should have taken. Gross ITC in Table 6 minus reversals in Table 7 is the net credit that actually funded your output tax.

Row	Reason for reversal	Where it bites
7A	Credit on inward supplies declared in GSTR-3B but not received in the year, later reversed	Timing gaps with suppliers

Row	Reason for reversal	Where it bites
7B	Credit availed on receipt but invoice not received within 180 days	Rule 37, common with contractors
7C	Credit availed but supplier did not pay tax — Rule 37A	Suppliers who stopped filing GSTR-3B
7D	Credit on inward supplies that became ineligible, section 17(5)	Motor vehicles, food and beverages, club membership, works contract for immovable property
7E	Credit reversed under Rule 42 or Rule 43	Common credit used partly for exempt supplies
7F	Reversal of transitional credit under TRAN-1	Legacy credits; nil for most businesses
7G	Reversal of transitional credit under TRAN-2	Legacy credits; nil for most businesses
7H	Any other reversal	Everything that does not fit above — explain it in your working paper

For FY 2025-26 the option to lump rows 7A to 7E into 7H has been withdrawn. Each reversal reason must be reported in its own row. That is more work in December and less work in 2028, when a query arrives and the answer is already on the record.

Rule 37A deserves its own line here. Where you availed credit on an invoice that the supplier reported in GSTR-1 but never followed with a GSTR-3B by 30 September 2026, that credit must be reversed in a GSTR-3B filed on or before 30 November 2026. Miss the date and the amount is payable with interest under section 50. When the supplier eventually files, you may re-avail the credit in a later return — and Rule 37(4) confirms that the section 16(4) time limit does not apply to that re-availment.

Table 8 — the reconciliation table

Table 8 does not change your liability. It is the table that tells the department, and you, where the credit in the system and the credit in your returns diverged.

Row	Figure	Source
8A	ITC available to you for the year	GSTR-2B, built from your IMS actions since October 2025
8B	ITC availed in GSTR-3B for the year	Your twelve returns
8C	ITC of FY 2025-26 availed in FY 2026-27, up to 30 November 2026	GSTR-3B of April to November 2026
8D	Difference: 8A less 8B less 8C	Computed by the portal

A positive 8D is credit that was available and never taken. It is not a demand, and it does not make you liable for anything — but it is a clock. Under section 16(4) that credit can still be claimed in a GSTR-3B filed on or before 30 November 2026, provided GSTR-9 has not already been filed. A negative 8D is worse: it means you claimed more than the system shows available, and that is the shape of a DRC-01C or a section 73/74A demand.

The Table 8A download on the GSTR-9 dashboard gives you the invoice-level detail behind 8A. Open it, sort by supplier, and match the largest values first. In practice four or five suppliers account for most of any gap: a supplier who reported your invoice in the wrong month, a supplier whose GSTR-1

you rejected in IMS and never revisited, and a supplier who reported a credit note you never took into your books.

Table 9 — tax paid

Table 9 is the annual summary of tax, interest, late fee and penalty paid, head by head, split between payment in cash and payment by credit. It must tie to your electronic cash ledger and electronic credit ledger for the year. If it does not, stop: the mismatch is either a return you have not accounted for, or a ledger adjustment you have forgotten.

- Total tax paid in Table 9 should equal the sum of the twelve GSTR-3B payments, not the sum of the tax on your invoices.
- Interest and late fee paid during the year belong here too, even where they relate to earlier periods.
- Any shortfall you find while reconciling is paid through FORM GST DRC-03 before the annual return is filed — not through a fresh GSTR-3B that does not exist any more for that period.
- A differential payment made through DRC-03 is disclosed in Table 14, and the DRC-03 reference is what makes the return internally consistent.

PART 5

The four bridges

Tables 10 to 14, and the 30 November window

Tables 10 to 14 exist because a financial year and a filing year are not the same thing. An invoice dated 28 March 2026 may have been reported in the GSTR-1 of April 2026; a credit note for a March sale may have been issued in May. Those movements belong to FY 2025-26 in substance, and these tables are where they are disclosed.

The reporting window for these bridges is the period from 1 April 2026 to **30 November 2026**. That is the same date as the section 16(4) window, and it is not a coincidence: the Finance Act, 2022 moved both to 30 November, effective 1 October 2022.

Table	What it carries	How to fill it
10	Outward supplies of FY 2025-26 declared late, or amended, in FY 2026-27 up to 30 November 2026	Pull the GSTR-1 and GSTR-1A filings of April to November 2026 and extract every line with a document date in FY 2025-26
11	Credit notes, debit notes and amendments relating to those supplies	Same pull, Table 9B and amendment rows only
12	ITC relating to FY 2025-26 reversed in FY 2026-27	GSTR-3B Table 4(B)(2) of April to November 2026
13	ITC relating to FY 2025-26 availed in FY 2026-27	GSTR-3B Table 4(A)(5) of April to November 2026
14	Differential tax paid on the supplies in Tables 10 and 11	DRC-03 payments made for FY 2025-26 differences

The relaxations that once let businesses leave Tables 12 and 13 blank were withdrawn from FY 2024-25. Both must be filled now. Tables 15 and 16 remain optional, and Table 18, the inward HSN summary, is optional as well.

THE TRAP IN TABLE 13

Table 13 is credit of FY 2025-26 claimed in FY 2026-27. If you claim that credit in a GSTR-3B filed after 30 November 2026, the claim is barred by section 16(4) and Table 13 will show a number the department can read as an excess claim. Sequence matters: last GSTR-3B by 30 November, then the annual return.

PART 6

The tail of the form

Tables 15 to 19: demands, composition, HSN and late fee

Table	Content	Status for FY 2025-26
15	Demands raised and refunds claimed or sanctioned during the year	Optional — but fill it if you had either
16	Inward supplies from composition taxpayers, goods sent for job work, goods sent on approval and not returned	Optional; mandatory in substance if any of the three applies
17	HSN or SAC summary of outward supplies	Mandatory. Six digits where the preceding year's turnover exceeded ₹5 crore; four digits for B2B supplies otherwise
18	HSN or SAC summary of inward supplies	Optional
19	Late fee payable and paid	Auto-computed by the portal when you press Compute Liabilities

Table 15 is optional; ignoring it is not free

If a demand was confirmed against you during FY 2025-26 and you paid it, Table 15 is where the payment is acknowledged. If a refund was sanctioned, this is where it appears. Leaving it blank when either happened does not create a liability, but it does create a difference between the annual return and the departmental ledger, and differences get letters.

Table 16 and the job-work trap

Goods sent to a job worker under section 143 and not returned within the permitted period are treated as a supply from the date they were sent. If you have stock sitting with a job worker for more than a year, Table 16 is where that exposure surfaces — and it is far cheaper to fix in December than in an audit.

Table 17: the HSN decision, and the 2025 rate change

The six-digit rule turns on the preceding financial year's turnover, so for FY 2025-26 it is FY 2024-25 turnover that decides. Above ₹5 crore, report six-digit HSN for outward supplies. At or below ₹5 crore, four digits is enough, and only for B2B supplies.

Whichever applies, FY 2025-26 is the first year in which the HSN summary has to survive the 22 September 2025 rate change. The same HSN code can now appear at two rates in the same return — a 12% line for April to 21 September and a 5% line from 22 September. Report them as separate rows by rate. Merging them into one row makes the tax column arithmetically wrong and is the single easiest way to make Table 17 disagree with Table 4.

Table 19 is computed, not typed. Press Compute Liabilities and the portal works out the late fee from the due date to the filing date, on the turnover slabs in Part 12. You cannot file until it is paid, which

is why the number should never be a surprise — calculate it in advance with Part 12 and budget for it.

PART 7

The GST 2.0 split year

How 22 September 2025 lands in an annual return

FY 2025-26 is the first financial year to contain two rate regimes. The 56th GST Council meeting on 3 September 2025 replaced the four-slab structure of 5%, 12%, 18% and 28% with a merit rate of 5% and a standard rate of 18%, plus a 40% special rate for a short list of demerit and luxury goods. The changes took effect on 22 September 2025 for services and for all goods other than a specified tobacco group.

Rate	What sits there now	Examples
0.25%	Rough diamonds, precious and semi-precious stones	Uncut gemstones
1.5%	Cut and polished diamonds	Loose polished diamonds
3%	Precious metals and pearls	Gold, silver, jewellery
5%	Merit rate — 516 categories of goods and services	Packaged food, hair oil, toothpaste, bicycles, medicines, tractors, hotel rooms up to ₹7,500 a day, gyms, salons, yoga centres
12%	Retained for one category of goods only	Bricks, other than sand lime bricks
18%	Standard rate — 640 categories	Machinery, chemicals, paints, auto parts, cement, TVs, small cars, motorcycles up to 350cc
28% plus cess	Specified tobacco group, pending the cess loan discharge	Cigarettes, pan masala, gutkha, chewing tobacco, bidi
40%	Special demerit and luxury rate	Aerated and caffeinated drinks, large cars above 1500cc or 4000mm, motorcycles above 350cc, yachts, private aircraft, online money gaming, betting, casinos, lottery

Two details that catch people in the annual return. First, cement moved from 28% to 18%, and small cars from 28% to 18% — so a dealer's Table 4 for the year contains the same goods at two rates. Second, pan masala, gutkha, cigarettes, chewing tobacco, unmanufactured tobacco and bidi continued at their existing rates and cess until the compensation cess loan and interest obligations are discharged, with GST now levied on retail sale price rather than transaction value for that group. A trader in that group has a mid-year basis change, not just a rate change.

Five places the split year shows up in GSTR-9

1. **Table 4 vs Table 17.** Aggregate turnover in Table 4 is rate-agnostic; Table 17 is not. Split each HSN by rate period or the two tables will disagree.
2. **Credit notes across the change.** A credit note issued in October 2026 against a July 2025 invoice at 12% is a next-year bridge entry (Tables 10 and 11), and its tax must be reversed at the rate originally charged — not at the new rate.

3. **Invoice-date discipline.** The rate depends on the date of supply, which for goods is generally the invoice date and for services the invoice or payment date, whichever is earlier. If your software applied the new rates from 1 October instead of 22 September, the error is in a week of September invoices and it will appear as an output tax gap between Table 4 and Table 9.
4. **Inverted duty structures that were corrected.** Manmade fibre fell from 18% to 5% and manmade yarn from 12% to 5%; fertiliser inputs such as sulphuric acid, nitric acid and ammonia fell from 18% to 5%. If you held accumulated credit from the old structure, check whether it is still eligible and whether any of it needs a Rule 42 or Rule 43 reversal.
5. **Services at 5%.** Hotel accommodation up to ₹7,500 per unit per day, gyms, salons, barbers and yoga centres moved to 5%. A salon or gym whose Table 4 shows 18% for the whole year has a rate error running from 22 September.

THE RECONCILIATION THAT CATCHES ALL FIVE

Take your sales register and split it at 21 September and 22 September 2025. For each side, recompute tax at the rate that should have applied and compare to the tax actually charged. The difference, if any, is the figure that has to be settled through DRC-03 and disclosed in Table 14 — before the annual return is filed.

PART 8

IMS and Table 8A

Why this year's credit figure is not the same as last year's

The Invoice Management System has been live on the portal since the October 2024 tax period, but until the October 2025 period it was a convenience. Since then it is the mechanism: section 38 was substituted by Notification No. 16/2025-Central Tax dated 17 September 2025, and from that period GSTR-2B is generated from the action a recipient takes on each record.

Your IMS action	Effect on GSTR-2B	Effect on your credit
Accept	Invoice flows into 2B	Credit available, auto-populates GSTR-3B
Reject	Invoice excluded from 2B	No credit; the supplier can correct it through GSTR-1A or a later GSTR-1
Keep pending	Held out of 2B for that period	Credit deferred, but the section 16(4) clock keeps running
No action	Deemed accepted when 2B is generated on the 14th	Credit available — including any error the supplier reported

Two consequences follow. Inaction is acceptance, so a supplier's keying error — a value entered as one lakh instead of ten thousand — inflates your credit unless you catch it in IMS before the 14th. And once the GSTR-3B for a period is filed, that period's IMS actions lock: a wrongly rejected invoice cannot be pulled back into that month's 2B and must wait for the supplier to report it again, inside the section 16(4) window.

From the October 2025 period, credit notes and certain amendments can also be kept pending, but only for one tax period — one month, or one quarter for a QRMP recipient. After that, pending is disabled and the record is deemed accepted if you do nothing.

What this means for Table 8A

Table 8A of GSTR-9 now draws on IMS data. Invoices you accepted, or left untouched, are in 8A. Invoices you rejected or kept pending are out of 8A until accepted. Two practical points:

- Table 8A pulls by document date, not by reporting period. An FY 2025-26 invoice that your supplier reported late and that appeared in your GSTR-2B of FY 2026-27 still lands in your FY 2025-26 Table 8A.
- IMS does not create or destroy eligibility. Section 16 still decides whether credit is yours; IMS decides only what the system shows you. A rejected invoice is not automatically ineligible, and an accepted one is not automatically eligible.

The pre-return IMS clean-up, in four steps

1. Open IMS and export the year's action history: accepted, rejected, pending, with remarks.

2. For every rejected record, write one line saying why — wrong GSTIN, not received, duplicate, rate dispute. This is what you will need if a query arrives in 2028.
3. For every record still pending, decide now. If the supply was received and the invoice is in GSTR-2B, accept it and claim the credit before 30 November 2026.
4. Reconcile the export to Table 8A's download. Where 8A is higher than your books, the difference is either credit you missed or a supplier's error; both need an answer before the return is filed.

PART 9

The ITC clean-up

Everything that must be finished by 30 November 2026

If you do only one thing this fortnight, do this: close out FY 2025-26 credit before you touch GSTR-9. The provisions below all share the same cut-off — 30 November following the end of the financial year, or the date of furnishing the annual return, whichever is earlier.

Provision	What it allows or requires	Practical effect for FY 2025-26
Section 16(4)	Claim credit on an invoice or debit note	Last GSTR-3B on or before 30 November 2026, or the GSTR-9 date if earlier
Section 34(2)	Issue a credit note for a supply of the year	Credit notes for FY 2025-26 must be issued and reported by 30 November 2026
Section 37(3)	Amend an outward supply already reported	GSTR-1 amendments for FY 2025-26 close on 30 November 2026
Section 39(9)	Correct an error in a return of the year	Correction by 30 November 2026, or through the annual return where the law allows
Rule 37A	Reverse credit where the supplier never filed GSTR-3B	Reverse in a GSTR-3B filed by 30 November 2026, or pay with interest
Rule 37	Pay the supplier within 180 days	Reversal with interest if unpaid; re-avail when paid

THE QRMP TRAP

A quarterly filer's last GSTR-3B before 30 November 2026 is the July to September 2026 quarter, due 22 or 24 October 2026 by State. The October to December return is not due until January 2027 — too late. If you are on QRMP and still have FY 2025-26 credit to claim, the window has already closed unless you have already filed that quarterly return. Check before you promise anyone a recovery.

Four kinds of credit, four different answers

Situation	What to do	Where it lands
Invoice in GSTR-2B, never claimed in 3B	Claim in the last 3B on or before 30 November 2026	Table 13 of GSTR-9, and Table 8C
Invoice claimed, supplier never filed GSTR-3B by 30 September 2026	Reverse by 30 November 2026; re-avail when the supplier files	Table 7C, then Table 6H on re-availment
Invoice claimed, supplier paid but you rejected it in IMS by mistake	Ask the supplier to report it again in a later GSTR-1; claim within the 16(4) window	Table 13, or the next year's return
Credit availed on goods used for exempt supplies	Reverse the attributable portion under Rule 42 or 43	Table 7E

Interest, if you get it wrong

Interest on tax paid late runs at 18% per annum under section 50(1). Where credit is wrongly availed and utilised, the rate is 24% per annum under section 50(3), read with Rule 88B. The difference between the two rates is the reason a wrong ITC claim is far more expensive than a late payment of the same amount, and it is why the reconciliation in Part 3 is worth the afternoon it takes.

Interest on a delayed payment is computed on the tax paid through the electronic cash ledger, from the due date of the return to the date of payment. For credit wrongly utilised, Rule 88B(3) provides the mechanism for computing interest on the portion of credit that remained unutilised, so a business that availed excess credit but never used it pays less than one that did. Keep the working either way.

Paying a difference without inviting a notice

Where the reconciliation shows tax short paid for FY 2025-26, the clean route is FORM GST DRC-03: pay the tax with interest, quote the reason, and disclose the payment in Table 14 of GSTR-9. Section 74A gives a person who pays before a notice is issued a materially better position on penalty than one who waits, and a voluntary payment with a documented reason is the version of this story an officer can close.

Do not attempt to fix a prior-year shortfall by over-reporting in a current GSTR-3B without disclosure. Since July 2025 the outward liability in GSTR-3B is auto-populated from GSTR-1 and cannot be edited, so the attempt usually creates a second mismatch instead of curing the first.

PART 10

Mismatch intimations

DRC-01B and DRC-01C, and what to do in seven days

Before any officer looks at your annual return, the system may already have written to you. DRC-01B and DRC-01C are intimations generated by the portal, not show-cause notices, and each gives seven days to pay or explain. Ignoring one blocks your next GSTR-1 under Rule 59(6), which in practice stalls the GSTR-3B after it.

	DRC-01B	DRC-01C
Rule	88C	88D
What it compares	Liability declared in GSTR-1 or IFF against liability discharged in GSTR-3B	Credit available in GSTR-2B against credit availed in GSTR-3B
Which side	Output tax	Input tax credit
Time to respond	7 days	7 days
If you do nothing	Next GSTR-1 or IFF blocked; the unpaid difference is recoverable under section 79 because section 75(12) treats declared-but-unpaid tax as self-assessed	Next GSTR-1 or IFF blocked; the excess credit can be taken up under section 73 or, for FY 2024-25 onwards, section 74A
Part A	The system's computation of the difference, head by head	The same, on the credit side
Part B	Your reply: pay through DRC-03, explain, or both	Your reply: pay through DRC-03, explain, or both

THE THRESHOLD IS NOT PUBLISHED, SO DO NOT PLAN AROUND IT

Rules 88C and 88D leave the amount and percentage to the portal, on the GST Council's recommendation. The figure usually quoted is a difference of more than 20% and more than ₹25 lakh, but it is a recommendation, not a notified safe harbour, and practitioner reports describe intimations on smaller gaps. Treat any material difference between your returns as live.

The practical pressure of DRC-01B has fallen since July 2025, because outward liability in GSTR-3B is now auto-populated from GSTR-1 and cannot be edited — the classic version of that mismatch cannot be created by typing a smaller number into Table 3.1 any more. Older periods can still produce one. DRC-01C has not become any less common, because it is driven by IMS rejections, pending records and suppliers who report late.

How to reply so the matter ends there

1. Download Part A and read the period it covers. It compares one tax period, not the year.
2. Match the gap to a document. In most cases it is one of four things: a supplier's invoice reported in the wrong month, a credit note you took in a different period, an RCM entry recorded on one

side only, or a genuine excess claim.

3. If it is genuine, pay through DRC-03 with interest and quote the reference in Part B. That closes it.
4. If it is not, explain in Part B with the working attached — invoice numbers, dates and the return in which each was reported. A one-line denial without documents usually produces a second letter.
5. Keep a copy of Part B and the DRC-03 in the FY 2025-26 folder. This is the paper trail that keeps the item out of your GSTR-9C and out of a section 74A notice.

PART 11

GSTR-9C

The reconciliation statement above ₹5 crore

Rule 80(3) requires a self-certified reconciliation statement in FORM GSTR-9C where aggregate turnover during the financial year exceeds ₹5 crore. It is filed along with GSTR-9, by the same date. It is not an audit, and since 1 August 2021 it has not needed a chartered accountant's certification: the Finance Act, 2021 amended sections 35(5) and 44, and Notifications 29/2021 and 30/2021-Central Tax operationalised the change. No UDIN is generated for GSTR-9C on the portal.

The authorised signatory — proprietor, partner, director or authorised representative — certifies it. That makes the declaration personal: an incorrect certification can attract penalty under section 122, and prosecution is not excluded for a false statement. Most businesses above ₹5 crore will still have their CA prepare it, because the reconciliation work is a natural extension of the statutory audit. What changed is that the signature is yours.

FILING GSTR-9 DOES NOT STOP THE CLOCK

CBIC Circular No. 246/03/2025-GST dated 30 January 2025 settles this. Where a GSTR-9C is required, the annual return under section 44 is complete only when both forms are filed. Late fee therefore runs from 1 January 2027 until the later of the two filings. A company that files GSTR-9 on 31 December 2026 and GSTR-9C on 15 March 2027 has not filed on time by zero days; it has filed 74 days late on every GSTIN where a 9C was due.

What GSTR-9C actually asks

Part	Content	The reconciliation it performs
Part I	Basic details: financial year, GSTIN, legal name, trade name	Identification only
Part II	Reconciliation of turnover	Turnover per audited financial statements against turnover declared in GSTR-9, with reasons for every difference
Part III	Reconciliation of tax payable and paid	Tax payable per books against tax paid, split by head, with reasons
Part IV	Reconciliation of input tax credit	ITC per books against ITC availed, including credit notes and reversals
Part V	Additional liability and the declaration	Any additional liability due, whether paid through DRC-03, and the self-certification

The five differences that explain most 9C reconciliations

- **Unbilled revenue.** Invoiced in April 2026, earned in March 2026. It is in the financial statements for FY 2025-26 and not in GSTR-1 for that year. Disclose it in the turnover bridge, not as an error.

- **Credit notes after year-end.** Issued in FY 2026-27 against FY 2025-26 sales. They reduce books turnover in the later year and GSTR-1 of the later year; the bridge explains the timing.
- **Reverse charge.** RCM inward supplies add to cost and to credit but not to outward turnover. A 9C that ignores them will not balance on the ITC side.
- **Branch and job-work transfers.** Transfers between registrations of the same PAN are supplies for GST and not revenue in the financial statements, or the reverse, depending on how the accounts are drawn.
- **Rounding and rate differences.** Small, cumulative and the easiest to dismiss — and the fastest way to have a reconciliation rejected as not genuine. Quantify it and label it.

Build the three bridges on one page each, in the order the form asks: turnover, tax, credit. A 9C that reconciles in three tables is defensible; one that reconciles in a single plug figure is not.

PART 12

Late fee and interest

The arithmetic, before the portal does it for you

Late fee for the annual return is levied under section 47(2) of the CGST Act, which provides ₹100 per day per Act, capped at a quarter per cent of turnover in the State. The State GST Act carries an identical provision, so the real figures are double. Notification No. 07/2023-Central Tax dated 31 March 2023 then reduced the rates for FY 2022-23 onwards, on a turnover-slab basis.

Aggregate turnover for the year	Late fee per day (CGST + SGST)	Maximum late fee
Up to ₹5 crore	₹50 (₹25 + ₹25)	0.04% of turnover in the State or UT
Above ₹5 crore, up to ₹20 crore	₹100 (₹50 + ₹50)	0.04% of turnover in the State or UT
Above ₹20 crore	₹200 (₹100 + ₹100)	0.5% of turnover in the State or UT

Two details people get wrong. The per-day figure applies **per registration**: four late GSTINs means four late fees, not one. And the slab is decided by aggregate turnover, while the cap is a percentage of turnover in that State — so a group with a large all-India turnover and a small State registration can sit in the ₹200-a-day slab with a cap it reaches almost immediately.

Four worked examples

1. The ordinary trader. Aggregate turnover ₹3.2 crore, all in Maharashtra. GSTR-9 filed 20 February 2027 instead of 31 December 2026: 51 days late. Fee at ₹50 a day is ₹2,550. The cap is 0.04% of ₹3.2 crore, or ₹12,800. You pay ₹2,550.

2. The mid-sized company. Aggregate turnover ₹18 crore, Karnataka turnover ₹6 crore. Filed 14 February 2027: 45 days late. Fee at ₹100 a day is ₹4,500. The cap is 0.04% of ₹6 crore, or ₹24,000. You pay ₹4,500.

3. Where the cap binds. Aggregate turnover ₹30 crore, but the Gujarat registration carries only ₹10 lakh. Filed 60 days late. Fee at ₹200 a day is ₹12,000; the cap is 0.5% of ₹10 lakh, or ₹5,000. You pay ₹5,000 — and the same 60 days on a ₹30 crore State registration would have cost ₹12,000.

4. The 9C trap. Aggregate turnover ₹8 crore. GSTR-9 filed on 31 December 2026, GSTR-9C on 15 March 2027. Under Circular 246/03/2025-GST the return was complete only on 15 March, so the delay is 74 days at ₹100 a day: ₹7,400 on each GSTIN where a 9C was due. File both on the same day.

Interest

Interest is separate from late fee and is charged on tax, not on the return. For tax paid late, 18% per annum under section 50(1). For credit wrongly availed and utilised, 24% per annum under section 50(3) with Rule 88B. Where a reconciliation identifies a shortfall, calculate both before you decide how to pay it: a ₹1 lakh shortfall paid eighteen months late at 18% carries roughly ₹27,000 of interest, which is usually more than the tax itself in a small business.

BUDGET IT NOW, NOT IN DECEMBER

Late fee is a known quantity before you file. Compute it from the table above, get it approved, and keep the cash ready: the portal will not accept the return until the fee is paid, and a payment that fails on 31 December at 11 pm is a delay measured in days of interest.

PART 13

The cost of not filing

What actually happens, and how long it stays open

Consequence	Provision	What it means in practice
Late fee	Section 47(2) with Notification 07/2023	₹50 to ₹200 a day per GSTIN, capped as in Part 12, until the return is filed
General penalty	Section 125	A penalty that can extend to ₹25,000 for a contravention with no specific penalty attached
Credit lost for good	Section 16(4)	Unclaimed FY 2025-26 credit dies on 30 November 2026, or on the date the annual return is filed, whichever is earlier
Interest on unreversed credit	Rule 37A, section 50	Credit that should have been reversed becomes payable with interest
Recovery without adjudication	Section 75(12), section 79	Tax declared in GSTR-1 but not paid in GSTR-3B is treated as self-assessed and can be recovered directly
Long notice window	Section 74A	A show-cause notice for FY 2025-26 can be issued up to 30 June 2030, and the order within 12 months of the notice, extendable by six
Penalty on determination	Section 74A(5)	10% of tax or ₹10,000, whichever is higher, where there is no fraud; 100% of tax where there is
Record retention	Section 36	Records must be kept for 72 months from the due date of the annual return — to 31 December 2032 for FY 2025-26

Section 74A replaced sections 73 and 74 for FY 2024-25 onwards. It unified the limitation periods: 42 months from the due date of the annual return for every case, fraud or not, with no notice at all where the tax involved is less than ₹1,000. For FY 2025-26, whose annual return is due 31 December 2026, that puts the outer limit for a notice at 30 June 2030.

That long window is the reason a filed return is not the end of the story. The return you file in December 2026 becomes the baseline against which everything from 2027 to 2030 is measured. A return that reconciles to a working paper closes the matter quietly. A return filed from auto-populated numbers with unexplained differences invites the letter.

WHERE THE REAL MONEY GOES

In most small businesses the late fee is not the expensive part. The expensive part is the credit that expires on 30 November because nobody looked, and the interest at 24% on credit that should have been reversed. Both are avoidable in November and unfixable in January.

PART 14

Filing day

A runbook, in order, with the things that break

Before you log in

1. Confirm every GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for FY 2025-26 is filed. One pending return keeps GSTR-9 locked.
2. Clear every DRC-01B and DRC-01C Part B reply. An open intimation blocks GSTR-1 and, in practice, everything after it.
3. Confirm the last GSTR-3B on or before 30 November 2026 is filed, with every FY 2025-26 credit you intend to claim.
4. Decide whether GSTR-9C applies: aggregate turnover above ₹5 crore, tested at PAN level.
5. Compute the late fee yourself (Part 12) and keep the cash ready in the electronic cash ledger.
6. Download and save: the twelve GSTR-2B statements, the IMS action export, the Table 8A document Excel, and the electronic cash and credit ledger for the year.

On the portal

1. Log in with the primary authorised signatory's credentials.
2. Go to Services, then Returns, then Annual Return. Select FY 2025-26.
3. Choose Prepare Online for a straightforward year, or download the offline utility where the HSN and ITC tables are large.
4. Check the auto-populated figures in Tables 4, 5, 6, 8 and 9 against your working paper before typing anything.
5. Fill Tables 7, 10 to 14 and 17 from the sheet. Leave 15, 16 and 18 at nil only if they genuinely do not apply.
6. Press Compute Liabilities. Read the late fee it calculates against your own figure. Investigate any difference.
7. Preview the draft return. Read every page of the preview, not just the summary.
8. File with DSC or EVC. Note the ARN.
9. File GSTR-9C on the same day if it applies, before you close the browser.

After you file

- Download the filed GSTR-9 and GSTR-9C PDFs and the acknowledgement. Store them with the working paper.
- Reconcile the electronic credit ledger after filing. A filing that consumed credit you did not expect is a reversal you missed.
- Note the section 16(4) position for FY 2026-27 in your calendar now: 30 November 2027, and it moves earlier if you file next year's return early.

- Set a reminder for 1 October 2027 to start the next cycle. Businesses that begin in October finish in December; businesses that begin in December file in January.

IF THE PORTAL THROWS AN ERROR

Most GSTR-9 filing failures come from four causes: a table left inconsistent with an auto-populated one, a negative value where the form expects a positive, a missing HSN row for a supply that appears in Table 4, and an unpaid late fee. Fix the data, not the error message. Never attempt to file by deleting a row that disagrees with the auto-populated figure — the disagreement is the information.

PART 15

Fifteen mistakes that cost money

Each with the fix, in one line

1. Filing GSTR-9 before claiming pending credit

Section 16(4) closes on the filing date. Claim in the last GSTR-3B first, then file.

2. Testing the ₹2 crore threshold on one State's turnover

Aggregate turnover is PAN-level and all-India. Add every GSTIN before deciding you are exempt.

3. Filing GSTR-9 and leaving GSTR-9C for later

Circular 246/03/2025-GST: late fee runs to the later filing. File both the same day.

4. Treating Table 8D as a demand

8D is a disclosure of difference, not a liability. Investigate it, do not pay it blindly.

5. Claiming missed credit inside GSTR-9

GSTR-9 cannot create credit. Use a GSTR-3B filed by 30 November, or DRC-03 for a tax difference.

6. Leaving Table 4L at nil because the landlord is unregistered

RCM on rent, legal fees, GTA freight and imported services must appear in 4L and in 3B Table 3.1(d).

7. Merging the pre and post 22 September 2025 rates in Table 17

Split the HSN row by rate. One merged row makes the tax column wrong and breaks the tie to Table 4.

8. Ignoring IMS rejections until December

Rejected and pending records stay out of 2B and out of Table 8A. Decide each one before 30 November.

9. Not reversing Rule 37A credit

Supplier's GSTR-3B not filed by 30 September 2026 means reversal by 30 November 2026, or interest under section 50.

10. Reporting four-digit HSN when six is required

The test is FY 2024-25 turnover above ₹5 crore. Six digits for outward supplies.

11. Forgetting a cancelled GSTIN

A registration cancelled during the year still files for its active period, and still attracts its own late fee.

12. Not reconciling Table 9 to the cash and credit ledgers

The annual return must tie to the ledgers. If it does not, a return is missing from the sheet.

13. Paying a prior-year shortfall in a current GSTR-3B

Since July 2025 outward liability is auto-populated and uneditable. Use DRC-03 and disclose in Table 14.

14. Signing GSTR-9C without reading the bridges

The self-certification is the signatory's declaration. Incorrect certification can attract section 122 penalty.

15. Starting in December

The 30 November window closes first. A December start guarantees a missed credit and a rushed return.

PART 16

The 48-day plan

13 November to 31 December 2026

Dates	Do this	Output
13–16 Nov	Run the Part 2 turnover test at PAN level; list every GSTIN that must file; decide on GSTR-9C	A one-page scope note
17–19 Nov	Build the master working paper (Part 3); pull the twelve GSTR-2B, the IMS export and the Table 8A Excel	The sheet, with all eight reconciliations
20 Nov	File the October 2026 GSTR-3B with every FY 2025-26 credit you intend to claim	Credit secured before the window closes
21–25 Nov	Rule 37A reversals; credit notes for the year; GSTR-1 amendments for FY 2025-26	Section 34(2) and 37(3) positions closed
26–30 Nov	Final GSTR-3B on or before 30 November; IMS clean-up; DRC-03 for any identified shortfall	Every 30 November window closed
1–10 Dec	Draft GSTR-9 table by table from the sheet; do not type from the portal's numbers	A complete draft, checked against the sheet
11–20 Dec	Resolve every difference; compute late fee; prepare the three GSTR-9C bridges if applicable	A return that reconciles, and a 9C that does
21–27 Dec	Second-person review: read the draft against the checklist below, line by line	A reviewed draft
28–31 Dec	File GSTR-9 and GSTR-9C; download the filed forms and the ARN; archive the folder	A filed return, three days early

The one-page checklist

- ☐ Aggregate turnover computed at PAN level for FY 2025-26, with the working
- ☐ Every GSTIN listed, including those cancelled during the year
- ☐ GSTR-9C applicability decided, and recorded
- ☐ All GSTR-1, GSTR-3B and GSTR-1A filings for FY 2025-26 complete
- ☐ All DRC-01B and DRC-01C Part B replies filed
- ☐ Last GSTR-3B on or before 30 November 2026 filed, with catch-up credit claimed
- ☐ Rule 37A reversal identified and made
- ☐ Credit notes for FY 2025-26 issued and reported
- ☐ IMS action history exported; every rejected and pending record explained
- ☐ Table 8A Excel downloaded and reconciled to the sheet
- ☐ Table 4 rows 4A to 4N checked, including advances and RCM
- ☐ Table 5 clubbing option used, with the split retained in the working
- ☐ Table 6 split by inputs, input services and capital goods
- ☐ Table 7 filled row by row, no lumping into 7H
- ☐ Table 8D difference quantified and explained
- ☐ Table 9 tied to the electronic cash and credit ledgers
- ☐ Tables 10 to 14 filled from the April to November 2026 returns
- ☐ Table 17 split by HSN and by rate across 22 September 2025
- ☐ Late fee computed independently and paid
- ☐ Differential tax, if any, paid through DRC-03 and disclosed in Table 14
- ☐ GSTR-9C bridges prepared where applicable, and signed by the authorised signatory
- ☐ Filed GSTR-9 and GSTR-9C PDFs and the ARN downloaded and archived
- ☐ Working paper, 2B downloads and IMS export stored with the return

APPENDIX

Sources and glossary

Where the positions in this kit come from

Primary sources to check before filing

- CGST Act, 2017: section 16(4) (time limit for credit), section 34(2) (credit notes), section 36 (records), section 37(3) (amendments), section 38 (communication of details of inward supplies), section 39(9) (corrections), section 44 (annual return), section 47(2) (late fee), section 50 (interest), section 74A (determination of tax, FY 2024-25 onwards), section 75(12) (self-assessed tax), section 125 (general penalty).
- CGST Rules, 2017: Rule 37 (180-day payment), Rule 37A (reversal where the supplier has not paid), Rule 42 and Rule 43 (common credit), Rule 59(6) (blocking of GSTR-1), Rule 80 (annual return and reconciliation statement), Rule 88B (interest), Rule 88C and Rule 88D (DRC-01B and DRC-01C).
- Notification No. 07/2023-Central Tax dated 31 March 2023: turnover-slab late fee for the annual return from FY 2022-23.
- Notification No. 15/2025-Central Tax dated 17 September 2025: ₹2 crore exemption from the annual return, FY 2024-25 onwards.
- Notification No. 16/2025-Central Tax dated 17 September 2025 and Notification No. 18/2025-Central Tax dated 31 October 2025: substituted section 38 and the IMS-based framework.
- CBIC Circular No. 246/03/2025-GST dated 30 January 2025: GSTR-9 and GSTR-9C together constitute the annual return, and late fee runs to the later filing.
- GST Council, 56th meeting, 3 September 2025: the two-rate structure of 5% and 18% with a 40% special rate, effective 22 September 2025, and the carve-outs for bricks and the specified tobacco group.
- GST portal user guides and FAQs on Form GSTR-9, including the Table 8A document download and the auto-population of Tables 4, 5, 6, 8 and 9.

Dates and thresholds in this kit were checked on 13 November 2026. GST returns, forms and portal behaviour change by notification, and a due date can be extended at short notice. Confirm the current position on gst.gov.in and cbic-gst.gov.in before you file.

Glossary

Term	Meaning in this kit
Aggregate turnover	All-India turnover of every registration under one PAN: taxable, exempt, exports and inter-State supplies, excluding GST and reverse-charge inward supplies
ARN	Acknowledgement Reference Number issued when a return is filed
DRC-03	Form for voluntary payment of tax, interest and penalty

Term	Meaning in this kit
GSTR-1 / 1A / IFF	Statement of outward supplies, its amendment form, and the Invoice Furnishing Facility used by QRMP filers
GSTR-2B	Static, auto-drafted statement of ITC available for a period, now built from IMS actions
GSTR-3B	Monthly or quarterly summary return on which tax is paid
GSTR-9 / 9C	Annual return and, above ₹5 crore, the self-certified reconciliation statement
IMS	Invoice Management System: accept, reject or keep pending each supplier record before GSTR-2B is generated
ITC	Input tax credit
QRMP	Quarterly Return, Monthly Payment scheme
RCM	Reverse charge mechanism: the recipient pays the tax
Rule 37A	Reversal of credit where the supplier reported the invoice but did not file GSTR-3B

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